

The Shot



SUMMARY

Addressing his former wife directly, Hughes says that Sylvia Plath needed godlike figures to worship and love, so she created them herself. The intensity of Plath's romantic passion transformed unremarkable, athletic young men into powerful, divine figures. Indeed, she seemed to have been born to seek out and find a godlike figure. Hughes compares Plath to a bullet in a gun that her father pointed toward God. Otto's death was the event that pulled the trigger on this metaphorical gun, shooting Plath off.

Plath's entire existence was contained within that gunshot (i.e., the moment of her father's death). She barrelled through her social and academic life with all the speed and power of an unstoppable bullet. The men she chose to love were destroyed when she hit them, too human to survive her intense devotion. They were immaterial and impermanent, nothing but obstacles on her flight path. Yet even through tear-soaked tissues and weekly panic attacks, beneath various hairstyles, behind what seemed like interruptions to her bullet-like trajectory through life, she remained steady and true. She was solid, a silver bullet wrapped in gold and tipped with nickel. She moved toward her target with perfect aim, as if through empty space. Even the scar on her cheek, which looked like she'd grazed her face against concrete, worked like a groove on the inside of a rifle's barrel to keep her steady on her course.

Until finally, her real target stood behind Hughes: her father, the god holding the gun that shot Plath through life. Because Hughes was indefinite and hazy, it took him a while to realize he had been hit by Plath's bullet-like passion, or that she had shot straight through him to lodge herself, with her death, in the heart of her father.

Hughes wonders if perhaps a traditional spiritual healer could have halted her bullet-like trajectory, catching her mid-flight and tossing her from one hand to the other until she was calm and happy, without the desire to find and worship a godlike paternal figure.

Hughes himself only managed to grasp at pieces of her: her hair, ring, watch, nightgown.

poem examines how Plath's intense—and, in the speaker's mind, obsessive—relationship with her father impacted her relationships with other men. The poem claims that Plath turned "ordinary" men into gods in the absence of her father, who died when she was eight. In other words, she pursued her lovers with an intensity bordering on religious devotion. The poem argues that this hunger for someone to "worship" was intensely destructive for Plath's lovers and, ultimately, for Plath herself.

Some background context is helpful here: Plath alternately idolized and resented her domineering father, Otto, who was a colossal presence in his daughter's life. His death proved immensely traumatic for the young Plath, who would spend much of her adulthood grappling with her feelings toward Otto. "Your Daddy had been aiming you at God / When his death touched the trigger," Hughes writes. This is an [allusion](#) to Plath's famous poem "[Daddy](#)," in which she compares her father to a tyrannical god and admits her own attempts to recreate their toxic dynamic by marrying Hughes, whom she presents as another overbearing man.

In "The Shot," however, Hughes asserts that Plath essentially sought to *turn* him into such a figure. He writes that Otto's death pulled the metaphorical trigger that shot Plath through life like a bullet, aimed at a god-like paternal presence who could fill the gap her father left behind. That is, Plath addressed the loss of her father by making the lovers caught in her path almost divine through the intensity of her "infatuation," or romantic obsession. She built these men up, the poem argues, allowing them to dominate her mind and life as gods would, even though they were nothing of the sort.

No man can survive such a thing, the speaker argues, and Plath's search for a new god to serve destroyed the "mortal[s]" she chose to devote herself to. "The elect," Hughes writes, were inevitably unable to live up to her god-like father and "more or less died on impact" with Plath. Her passion tore through them, her obsessive love leaving a trail of destruction in its wake.

Toward the end of the poem, the speaker becomes a victim of Plath's furious "flightpath," or her designated course through the air. "I did not even know / I had been hit," the speaker claims, comparing Plath's impact to a gunshot wound. Here, Hughes defends himself as not another tyrant, but rather another man Plath wounded in her ferocious search for someone to worship. "You had gone clean through me," Hughes writes, emphasizing the violence of Plath's worshipful love, which penetrates the heart like "a high-velocity bullet." The men in Plath's life seem less like gods than casualties.

Yet the poem allows that Plath was a victim here too. Alluding to her struggles with mental health and eventual suicide, the



THEMES



OBSESSIVE LOVE AND SELF-DESTRUCTION

In "The Shot," Ted Hughes speaks directly to his former wife Sylvia Plath, who died by suicide in 1963. The

poem suggests that Plath's search for a powerful male figure to adore destroyed not just her lovers, but herself as well. The speaker reveals that Plath's "real target" was never actually him, nor any of the other men she loved, but rather her "Daddy, / The god with the smoking gun." She was always shooting through life toward her father, until she could "bury [herself] at last in the heart of the god"—a reference to Plath's eventual death by suicide. If only Plath were "godless," the poem argues, she would have been "happy" and at peace. Instead, her desire to worship leads her toward destruction: having finally hit her target, she, herself, was buried.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-8
- Lines 15-17
- Lines 32-38



FAMILY TRAUMA

In "The Shot," Ted Hughes addresses his former wife, the poet Sylvia Plath, who died by suicide in 1963.

The poem suggests that the death of Plath's father, Otto, in her childhood set her down her destructive path. Plath spent her "whole life" in search of a god-like paternal figure to love and "worship" in the absence of her father, who, in dying, had seemed to abandon her. Essentially, the poem argues that the intense trauma of losing Otto shaped the entire "trajectory" of Plath's life.

At the beginning of the poem, the speaker compares Plath to a bullet and states that her father's death "touched the trigger." In other words, the trauma of losing her father set Plath down an unalterable path, much like ammunition shot from a gun.

As the poem continues, the speaker describes how Plath tore through life with "fury" and "velocity." He mentions her "Alpha career," alluding to her intense ambition, which may have been rooted in a desire to live up to her deceased father's legacy of academic prestige. The speaker also references Plath's struggles with mental health, describing her tear-soaked tissues and "Saturday night panics." Clearly, the pain of her father's death and her fast-paced, destructive path took a toll on her emotional and psychological well-being.

Despite these pressures and struggles, Plath hurtled forward through life "undeflected." The speaker claims that even her "cheek-scar" (a remnant of a suicide attempt Plath made in 1953) worked like a "rifling groove," or a groove within the barrel of a gun that helps a bullet steadily follow its intended course. Plath's struggles with mental health did nothing to slow her "flightpath," but rather stemmed directly from the trauma of losing her father and sped her ever faster on her destructive trajectory.

This deadly trajectory only came to an end when Plath reunited

with her father in death: Plath passed "clean through" the speaker to embed herself "in the heart of the god," with "god" here being a reference to Otto. The poem thus suggests that in a sense, the unresolved trauma and pain of losing Otto led directly to Plath's own tragic death as she sought to return to that trauma's source.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 7-17
- Lines 20-25
- Lines 28-31
- Lines 39-42
- Lines 43-44



POWER, FATE, AND AGENCY

In "The Shot," Ted Hughes examines the impact of Sylvia Plath's relationship with her deceased father, Otto, on her relationships with other men. As the speaker compares Plath's relentless search for her father within the men she loves to the "flightpath" of a "bullet," the poem emphasizes Plath's own god-like ability to deify and destroy her lovers. At the same time, however, the poem hints at Plath's ultimate powerlessness over her own life: in the speaker's portrayal, she was merely the object shot from the gun rather than the divine, masculine hand that pulled the trigger. For all her bullet-like speed and ferocity, the poem suggests, she was incapable of choosing her own path and ultimately beholden to a destiny "designed at birth."

The poem argues that Plath's efforts to worship other men in the absence of her father were largely futile, and she tore through her lovers "With the fury / of a high velocity bullet." No "mortal" man could live up to the image in her mind of Otto or withstand her passionate "infatuation," and so she continued to careen violently forward in an attempt to reach her absent, god-like father.

Yet even as Hughes accuses Plath of leaving a trail of violent destruction in her wake, he emphasizes her lack of agency. A bullet has no momentum on its own; Hughes attributes Plath's "velocity," her vicious speed, to her father's influence. "Your Daddy, / The god with the smoking gun," Hughes writes near the end of the poem. Here, the [idiom](#) "smoking gun" places blame on Plath's father for the destruction she caused in her search for him. She is the bullet, but Otto—with his overbearing presence and traumatic, untimely death—fired the gun.

"The Shot" further implies that Plath's struggles with mental illness were another aspect of the irreversible "flightpath" upon which Otto's death set Plath. The speaker notes her "sob-sodden Kleenex" and her "Saturday night panics, / Under your hair done this way and that way," reducing Plath's clinical depression to an image of tear-soaked tissues, pairing her "panics" with the trivial image of her hairstyles, and implicitly

dismissing the severity of her mental illness. Intentionally or not, the poem's male speaker minimizes Plath's struggles with mental health and, in turn, minimizes Plath's power over her own life.

Plath was always doomed, this poem ultimately suggests, and was never actually in control of her self-destructive destiny. It was as though she had "been designed at birth" to need someone to worship, fated by some outside force to pursue "a god" until it led to her grave. Indeed, the poem argues that although Plath destroyed the "mortal" men who crossed her bullet-like path, she was ultimately consumed by Otto (or, at least, by the trauma he caused): upon finally reaching her "real target," her father, Hughes says she was buried "at last in the heart of the god." This can be read as a reference to Plath's suicide, which the poem implies was both a way to get back to and back at her father (an idea Plath herself posed in her poem "[Daddy](#)").

In the poem's final stanza, the speaker blames himself for not stopping Plath's destruction. He suggests that someone else, "the right witchdoctor," perhaps, might have been able to stop Plath's fatal trajectory, healing her pain and making her "happy, quieted." Here, the poem emphasizes Plath's lack of agency once more. The speaker implies that only another masculine, divine figure—a "witchdoctor"—could alter the deadly course on which her father set her. Mortal men—and Plath herself—stood no chance against her fate.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 3-4
- Lines 7-17
- Lines 20-22
- Lines 32-34
- Lines 34-38
- Lines 39-44



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-6

*Your worship needed ...
... god-seeker. A god-finder.*

In the opening line of "The Shot," Ted Hughes uses [apostrophe](#) to address his deceased wife, the American poet Sylvia Plath: "Your worship needed a god," Hughes says. Right away, the use of the second person creates a sense of intimacy between the speaker and Plath, despite the great emotional and metaphysical distance between them (Plath and Hughes experienced severe marital troubles and were separated at the time of Plath's death by suicide in 1963).

According to the poem, Plath felt the need to devote herself with near-religious fervor to a strong, masculine figure, or "a

god." The phrasing of the poem's opening implies that it didn't matter all that much who this god was; she already had the "worship" and just needed a place to direct it.

Lacking an object for her devotion, Plath looked for divinity in unlikely places—among "Ordinary jocks," for example, whom the speaker claims Plath "Deified," or made god-like, through the sheer strength of her "infatuation," or romantic passion. In other words, Plath thought of and treated her lovers as though they were deities. They became all-powerful, the rulers of Plath's entire world.

The phrase "Ordinary jocks" is dismissive and hints at the speaker's disdain for these other men, whom he implies were far from god-like in reality. For a moment, then, the speaker's claim that Plath could make her lovers into gods might seem to grant Plath herself a sense of otherworldly power. After all, she's capable of transforming regular, everyday guys into divine beings—something she could presumably only do if she, herself, were divine.

However, lines 5 and 6 undermine this idea. For one thing, the speaker calls Plath's desire to worship mere "infatuation." This suggests that her passion for these men was obsessive and intense but also not as deep or meaningful as actual divine *love*.

The speaker then suggests that this "infatuation" was "**designed** at birth for a god." The word "designed" implies that Plath's tendency toward "infatuation" was in fact created by someone other than herself—likely, a masculine, all-powerful god like the one she sought in her lovers. Thus, these first few lines lay the groundwork for the poem's exploration of Plath's identity as a "god-seeker" and "god-finder" being rooted not in any real power of her own, but rather chosen or fated for her by some external force.

Notably, the word "god" appears five times within the poem's first six lines. This [repetition](#) mirrors Plath's own obsessive nature (in Hughes's estimation, at least). Just as she attempted to emulate a godlike presence in man after man, the poem invokes "god" in line after line.

LINES 7-10

*Your Daddy had ...
... your whole life.*

The speaker suggests that Plath's desire to "worship" a godlike figure was caused by the loss of her father, Otto, who died when she was a child:

Your Daddy had been aiming you at God
When his death touched the trigger.

Hughes is [alluding](#) in these lines to Plath's famous poem "[Daddy](#)," in which Plath describes Otto as an oppressive, godlike figure and suggests that she tried to recreate their troubled father-daughter relationship within her marriage to

Hughes. Hughes expands upon this idea in "The Shot," suggesting that Plath attempted to emulate her father not just in him personally but in *all* the men she loved.

Lines 7 and 8 also initiate an [extended metaphor](#) that the speaker will develop throughout the rest of the poem. The speaker claims that Plath's father aimed her like a gun "at God" and that "his death touched the trigger." Plath is the bullet in this metaphor, shot forth when her father's death pulls the "trigger." In other words, Otto's death determined Plath's direction in life, her intense desire to seek out "a god" to worship and adore.

By comparing her to an inanimate object shot from a gun, rather than to the hand that pulled the trigger, Hughes once again suggests Plath's lack of agency over her own life. Ultimately, the poem implies, it was Otto, or at least the trauma of his untimely death, that decided Plath's life course.

Lines 9 and 10 emphasize this idea. The speaker claims, "In that flash / You saw your whole life." In other words, in the moment of Otto's death—the moment *the shot* was fired, so to speak—the entire course of Plath's life was determined.

Line 9—"In that flash"—is the shortest in the poem, but the words are indented such that they protrude out along the poem's righthand margin. This formal decision serves two purposes:

1. First, it draws attention to the significance of the "flash" of Otto's death and its influence on Plath's life. The [enjambment](#) of this line contributes to this effect, drawing further attention to the word "flash" and mimicking the forward momentum created by a firing gun.
2. Second, it functions much like a traditional stanza break, signifying a new section of the poem, one which will follow the arc of Plath's metaphorical bullet path through life.

LINES 10-15

*You ricocheted ...
... Of kinetic energy.*

"The Shot" continues to develop its comparison of Plath to a bullet. [Metaphorically](#) triggered by her father's traumatic death, Plath "ricocheted" through life, the poem claims. When a bullet ricochets, it bounces off one or more surfaces before eventually meeting its target. The poem suggests that the powerful manner in which Plath moved through the world caused destruction to those who surrounded her.

Meanwhile, the words "Alpha career" [allude](#) to Plath's academic successes, which she approached with the "velocity" and "fury" of a "bullet." This intense, nearly violent desire for intellectual and social accomplishment can be read as Plath's attempt to live up to her father's expectations of scholastic prestige; Otto

was an entomologist and taught biology and German at Boston University, and she worshipped him as a little girl. By comparing her journey through school to the arc of a bullet, the poem emphasizes the destructive effects of the extreme pressure Plath felt to succeed as her father had.

Plath's path through life was not only as fast-paced and destructive as the path of a bullet, the poem continues, but also as relentless. In lines 14 and 15, the speaker claims that Plath:

*[...] cannot shed one foot-pound
Of kinetic energy.*

In other words, Plath could not be slowed down, not one tiny bit. This builds upon the idea, introduced in the poem's first 10 lines, that her father's death predetermined the trajectory of her life, which was therefore beyond her or anyone else's control.

Lines 10-15 are all [enjambéd](#). One line feeds directly into the next, without punctuation providing a moment to pause, such that the poem sounds hurried and chaotic. Its pace mirrors its description of Plath's pace as she moved through life; both the poem and Plath surge forward with a "velocity" that feels unstoppable.

LINES 15-19

*The elect ...
... along your flightpath.*

"The Shot" goes on to specify how Plath's bullet-like path through life affected those around her. "The elect / More or less died on impact," the speaker claims in lines 15 and 16. "The elect" refers to the "ordinary" men Plath chose to love with near-religious devotion.

Note, too, that in some Christian denominations, the "elect" refers specifically to people chosen by God for salvation. Hughes is thus using the term somewhat [ironically](#); the poem has already deemed these men "Ordinary jocks" and implied that there's nothing special or holy about them—only Plath's "infatuation" makes it so. Indeed, the poem claims that these men were ultimately "too mortal" to survive the powerful force of Plath's "infatuation." In other words, they failed to live up to Plath's expectations of masculine power and divinity, to adequately play the role of "god" for her. As such, they "died on impact"—as soon as they were hit with the [metaphorical](#) bullet of Plath's passion.

Note how the em-dash after the word "impact" acts as the first [end-stop](#) following a series of seven [enjambéd](#) lines in a row:

*[...] The elect
More or less died on impact—*

For a moment, the poem stops in its tracks, placing emphasis on the word "impact" and allowing the reader to pause and take in

the destruction left in Plath's wake.

Next, the speaker describes in detail the inconsequential, immaterial nature of the men Plath destroyed. "They were mind-stuff," he says, "Provisional, speculative, mere auras." Such words characterize Plath's "mortal" lovers as temporary and, in a sense, unreal. They were mere shadowy *projections* of the powerful, paternal figure Plath truly desired, the poem suggests. Meanwhile, the use of [asyndeton](#) in this list of descriptors contributes to the poem's fast, bullet-like pace, allowing it to regain the momentum built up through its many previous enjambed lines.

The speaker then refers to Plath's lovers as "Sound-barrier events," which are increases in aerodynamic drag as an object approaches the speed of sound. This suggests that these men are merely obstacles on Plath's "flightpath," or her planned course. The poem argues that though Plath attempted to emulate godliness within the men she loved, these "Deified" lovers could not compare to the truly godly, paternal figure she lost when her father died.

LINES 20-25

*But inside your ...
... You were undeflected.*

The speaker goes on to list several other seeming obstacles on Plath's "flightpath." In lines 20 and 21 he refers to her "sob-sodden Kleenex" and "Saturday night panics," both of which [allude](#) to Plath's struggles with clinical depression. In line 22, he describes her various hairstyles, perhaps in reference to Plath's attempts to conform to societal expectations of beauty and femininity. Lines 23 and 24, meanwhile, return to the language of the poem's [extended metaphor](#), referring to interruptions to a bullet's trajectory such as "rebounds" and "the cascade of cries diminuendo" (a musical term for a decrease in loudness or intensity).

It is worth noting how the poem uses [parallelism](#) to structure this list of would-be obstacles. Each is preceded by a preposition: "inside your sob-sodden Kleenex," "Under your hair done this way and that way," "Behind what looked like rebounds." This structure implies an equivalency between the three items in the list. In other words, Plath's struggles with mental health and her concern over her hairstyles are given equal weight by the speaker; both "looked like" deflections from her preset life course. In this way, the poem appears to minimize the severity of Plath's depression, particularly when considering the dismissive tone of the phrase "sob-sodden Kleenex" and the implied irrationality of "Saturday night panics."

In line 25, the speaker concludes this list of prepositional phrases by asserting, "You were undeflected." In other words, while Plath's depression and her concerns over her appearance might have appeared like interruptions to her bullet-like "Trajectory," she nonetheless remained steady and true to the

course upon which her father's premature death set her.

LINES 26-31

*You were gold-jacketed, ...
... keep you true.*

In lines 26-31, "The Shot" further develops its comparison of Plath to a bullet in order to illustrate the "undeflected" nature of her course through life. The speaker describes Plath as "gold-jacketed, solid silver, / Nickel-tipped," implying that she is built with the solidity and power of a bullet (and contrasting her with the insubstantial men through whom she tore). The use of [asyndeton](#) in this list of adjectives contributes to the poem's fast pace and sense of urgency.

The speaker also describes Plath as "Trajectory perfect / As through ether." In other words, Plath remained steadily on her set course as though she were moving through "ether," or the clear, uppermost region of the sky.

Next, the speaker again references the relationship between Plath's depression and her bullet-like "Trajectory":

*[...] Even the cheek-scar,
Where you seemed to have side-swiped concrete,
Served as a rifling groove
To keep you true.*

Here, "cheek-scar" [alludes](#) to a mark Plath sustained from her first suicide attempt at age 20. The poem compares the scar to a "rifling groove," or a groove within the barrel of a rifle that helps improve a bullet's aerodynamic stability and accuracy. In other words, rather than acting as a deterrent, Plath's suicide attempt actually helped her stay "true" to the path upon which her father's death set her. The poem suggests that Plath's bullet-like movement through life is destructive not just to those around her—the men who "died on impact," for example—but also to herself.

LINES 32-38

*Till your real ...
... of the god.*

Similar to line 9 ("In that flash"), line 32—"Till your real target"—is heavily indented, signaling a second significant shift in the poem's subject matter and pace:

- Lines 1-8 of the poem express how the death of Plath's father inspired her desire to devote herself to a powerful masculine figure.
- Lines 9-31 describe in detail the destructive life course upon which this childhood trauma set Plath.
- Here, in line 32, the [metaphorical](#) arc of Plath's bullet concludes—at last, she meets her "real target," the goal at which her father "had been aiming" her when he died. Functioning similarly to a stanza

break, the indentation of this line slows the poem down and draws attention to the phrase "real target."

The speaker claims that this "real target / Hid behind" him: "Your Daddy, / The god with the smoking gun." In this revelatory moment, the speaker identifies himself with Plath's other lovers, the "ordinary" and "mortal" men whom she tried, unsuccessfully, to make into gods. Similar to these "aura"-like and "provisional" lovers, he describes himself as "Vague as mist," a mere barrier between Plath and the true object of her devotion: her father, Otto.

All her life, the poem suggests, Plath tried to recreate or return to the godlike father she lost as a child. The [idiom](#) "smoking gun," which refers to a piece of undeniably incriminating evidence, highlights Otto's responsibility for Plath's fate. In other words, the trauma of Otto's death directly caused the events of Plath's life.

The speaker states that Plath shot "clean through" him, "To bury yourself at last in the heart of the god." Here, the truly self-destructive nature of Plath's furious, "high-velocity" path through life becomes clear. While Plath passed easily through the "mortal" men she loved, she was consumed entirely by the heart of her powerful father. Indeed, the word "bury" alludes to Plath's suicide—only by dying, herself, could she finally reunite with Otto. (Note that Hughes is once again in direct conversation with Plath's poem "[Daddy](#)" here, where Plath writes, "At twenty I tried to die / And get back, back, back to you. / I thought even the bones would do." Plath is describing an early suicide attempt as a way to return to her father.)

Earlier in "The Shot," the speaker suggested that Otto "had been aiming" Plath "at God" at the time of his death. Here, the poem reveals Otto himself to be the god that Plath constantly sought out. Thus, by the poem's estimation, Plath acted as the metaphorical bullet that ended Otto's life, just as Otto's "heart" metaphorically buried Plath. In this way, the poem highlights the intertwining of Otto and Sylvia Plath's fates through generational trauma; the destruction of the father ensured that of the daughter, and vice versa. In a sense, Plath's suicide allowed her not only to get back *to* but also to get back *at* her father. By metaphorically shooting Otto (and burying herself), Plath inflicted upon him the pain and destruction that he inflicted by "abandoning" her with his death.

LINES 39-44

*In my position, ...
... watch, your nightgown.*

Between lines 38 and 39, Hughes inserts the poem's one true stanza break. While the earlier indentations of lines 9 and 32 created pauses signaling minor tonal and thematic shifts, this full break mirrors the total silence after a gunshot. It signifies the end of Plath's bullet-like "Trajectory" and thereby the end

of her life.

In lines 39-42, Hughes laments his inability to halt Plath's self-destruction, suggesting that a different man might have been able to save her:

*In my position, the right witchdoctor
Might have caught you in flight with his bare hands,*

Here, "witchdoctor" refers to a traditional spiritual healer, or a shaman. The speaker suggests that such a figure might have been able to snatch bullet-like Plath from the air and toss her from "one hand to the other" like a hot potato, "cooling" her and leaving her "Godless, happy, quieted." In other words, someone else might have been able to cure her of her obsession with worshipping a godlike figure and, in doing so, of her depression and anxieties, allowing her to live a calm, fulfilled life.

In suggesting that only a "witchdoctor" could have saved Plath, however, the speaker reaffirms her lack of agency. Just as only a powerful, masculine figure—"your Daddy, / The god with the smoking gun"—could decide Plath's fate, only a powerful masculine figure could alter it. According to the speaker, Plath, herself, was never capable of changing her own "flightpath."

Like lines 9 and 32, line 43—"I managed" is indented, slowing the poem's pace as the speaker begins to consider his own relationship with Plath. Unable to stop Plath's destructive life course altogether, the speaker can only grasp at pieces of her: "A wisp of your hair, your ring, your watch, your nightgown." Here, in the poem's final line, [asyndeton](#) contributes to a sense of incompleteness. One might expect the conjunction "and" to be placed before the words "your nightgown," lending the phrase a sense of finality. By defying this expectation, the poem highlights how Plath's relationship with the speaker, and indeed her own life, lacked a proper, ceremonious conclusion, both being cut short unnaturally and prematurely.



POETIC DEVICES

EXTENDED METAPHOR

In "The Shot," Ted Hughes uses an [extended metaphor](#) to compare his deceased wife, the American poet Sylvia Plath, to a bullet. This comparison serves two major purposes.

First, it illustrates the fast-paced, focused, destructive manner in which Plath moved through life:

*[...] You ricocheted
The length of your Alpha career
With the fury
Of a high-velocity bullet*

The speaker refers here to Plath's academic success, which she pursued with great power and determination. When it comes

to Plath's lovers, meanwhile, the bullet metaphor highlights the disastrous effects of her worshipful, obsessive "infatuation." The speaker claims that "The elect," or the men Plath chose to love, "More or less died on impact," comparing the overwhelming force of Plath's passion to the force of a gunshot that tore through her paramours.

The poem also describes obstacles to Plath's "target," or her main goal in life (reunion with her father, Otto, who died when she was a child) in terms related to gunfire: "rebounds / And the cascade of cries diminuendo." Plath's bullet-like qualities allow her to bypass these obstacles "undeflected." Like a bullet, she was solid and strong: "gold-jacketed" and "Nickel-tipped." Like a bullet, she stayed "true" to her course, always aiming toward a masculine, godlike figure who could restore or replace the father she lost.

The poem's extended metaphor also demonstrates the relationship between the loss of Plath's father and her self-destructive fate. While the poem compares Plath to a bullet, it claims Otto aimed Plath "at God" and that his death "touched the trigger," shooting Plath down her "Trajectory" through life. In other words, the trauma of Otto's death led directly to Plath's self-destructive, obsessive desire to replicate his powerful presence in her life.

In this way, the poem suggests that Plath had little control over her own destiny. Instead, her life's events were predetermined by her father's death. Later in the poem, Otto is referred to as "The god with the smoking gun," an [idiom](#) that echoes the imagery of the extended bullet metaphor while also highlighting Otto's responsibility for Plath's life course. When Plath finally meets her "real target"—her father—the speaker describes the event like a bullet entering a body:

[...] you had gone clean through me—
To bury yourself at last in the heart of the god.

Here, the speaker describes how Plath metaphorically lodged herself like a bullet in Otto's heart, leading to her total consumption. In this way, the poem uses the extended metaphor to suggest that the death of Plath's father directly led to her own suicide. By pulling the metaphorical "trigger," the speaker argues, Otto's death set Plath down a path toward her own burial.

Where Extended Metaphor appears in the poem:

- Lines 7-16
- Line 19
- Lines 23-28
- Lines 30-31
- Lines 32-34
- Lines 35-38
- Lines 40-41

ASYNDETON

[Asyndeton](#) appears in several instances throughout "The Shot." For example, in lines 17-18, the poem uses asyndeton in a list of descriptors for Plath's "mortal lovers":

[...] They were mind-stuff,
Provisional, speculative, mere auras.

The technique appears again in lines 26-27, in a list of descriptors for Plath, herself:

You were gold-jacketed, solid silver,
Nickel-tipped. [...]

Both these instances occur in the middle section of the poem, in which the speaker describes Plath's furious, "high-velocity" "flightpath," or set course, through life. In both cases, the lack of any coordinating conjunctions, combined with the fact that the lists span two lines, creates a stumbling, piling-on effect that speeds the poem up, formally mirroring Plath's own rapid forward momentum.

Asyndeton also occurs twice in the poem's final stanza:

- First, the speaker imagines the possibility that another man could have saved Plath from her self-destructive fate, making her "Godless, happy, quieted."
- The speaker, himself, however, could not halt Plath's bullet-like trajectory and instead only managed to grasp at pieces of her: "A wisp of your hair, your ring, your watch, your nightgown."

The close proximity of these two uses of asyndeton highlights the tragic gap between what actually occurred and what the speaker imagines might have been. In the poem's final line, meanwhile, asyndeton creates a sense of incompleteness. A coordinating conjunction might provide this list of personal effects with a sense of finality. The lack of one, however, makes the poem's conclusion feel abrupt and unnatural—much like the end of the speaker and Plath's relationship, and indeed, the end of Plath's life.

Where Asyndeton appears in the poem:

- **Lines 17-18:** "They were mind-stuff, / Provisional, speculative, mere auras."
- **Lines 26-27:** "You were gold-jacketed, solid silver, / Nickel-tipped."
- **Line 42:** "Godless, happy, quieted."
- **Line 44:** "A wisp of your hair, your ring, your watch, your nightgown."

ENJAMBMENT

Frequent [enjambment](#) speeds up the pace of "The Shot," and it also calls attention to important words or ideas throughout the poem. For example, lines 9-15 comprise a series of seven enjambed lines:

In that flash
You saw your whole life. You **ricocheted**
The length of your Alpha **career**
With the **fury**
Of a high-velocity **bullet**
That cannot shed one foot-pound
Of kinetic **energy**. [...]

Here, the poem describes how the death of Plath's father (the [metaphorical](#) "flash" of a gun being fired) set Plath off like "a high-velocity bullet" down a furious, destructive life course. The many successive enjambed lines stumble quickly into one another, ramping up the poem's pace such that it mirrors the chaos and speed of Plath's bullet-like trajectory.

In other instances, enjambed lines highlight words that are significant to the poem's narrative and thematic ideas. Take, for example, the poem's three indented lines ("In that flash," "Till your real target," and "I managed"), all of which are enjambed. In line 9, enjambment calls attention to the word "flash," emphasizing the power and destruction of Otto's death, which the poem compares to a gunshot. In line 32, meanwhile, enjambment highlights the word "target," signaling to the reader that Plath's metaphorical "flightpath" has finally come to its conclusion. Finally, in line 43, the poem's final enjambed line, the word "managed" alludes to how the speaker's desperate attempt to save Plath was, in a sense, also an attempt to tame or control her.

Where Enjambment appears in the poem:

- **Lines 4-5:** "infatuation / That"
- **Lines 7-8:** "God / When"
- **Lines 9-10:** "flash / You"
- **Lines 10-11:** "ricocheted / The"
- **Lines 11-12:** "career / With"
- **Lines 12-13:** "fury / Of"
- **Lines 13-14:** "bullet / That"
- **Lines 14-15:** "foot-pound / Of"
- **Lines 15-16:** "elect / More"
- **Lines 20-21:** "Kleenex / And"
- **Lines 23-24:** "rebounds / And"
- **Lines 27-28:** "perfect / As"
- **Lines 30-31:** "groove / To"
- **Lines 32-33:** "target / Hid"
- **Lines 34-35:** "time / Vague"
- **Lines 35-36:** "know / I"

- **Lines 39-40:** "witchdoctor / Might"
- **Lines 43-44:** "managed / A"

REPETITION

"The Shot" [repeats](#) two important words throughout: "god" and "Daddy." The former appears six times in the first stanza alone (and nine times overall). The repetition of "god," with its harsh /g/ and /d/ sounds, occurs more frequently at the beginning of the poem and less so as it goes on, and in this way sonically mimics the fading reverberations of a gunshot, or, as the poem puts it, "the cascade of cries diminuendo."

Notably, the poem's opening section establishes Plath's obsession with worshipping and adoring a powerful male figure. The frequent repetition of the word "god," here and elsewhere in the poem, mirrors Plath's own obsession. The poem continually returns to the word "god," just as Plath longs to return to the godlike father she lost when her father, Otto, passed away. Lines 1, 3, and 5 all end with this word, almost creating [epistrophe](#):

Your worship needed a **god**.
[...]
Ordinary jocks became **gods**—
[...]
That seemed to have been designed at birth for a
god.

Then there's the particularly emphatic [parallelism](#) of "god-seeker" and "god-finder" in line 6, which highlights the idea that Plath created the gods she worshipped (wherever she sought them, there they'd be).

In its final appearance in the poem, the word "god" takes on a different form. The speaker imagines that a man more powerful than himself might have been able to halt Plath on her self-destructive path and make her "Godless, happy, quieted." Here, the word "Godless" emphasizes the inevitability of Plath's fate and the speaker's total inability to change it. "God" is present even within the very word ("Godless") which the speaker uses to imagine an alternate life for Plath, one in which she is not consumed by a desire for "worship."

The poem repeats the word "Daddy," meanwhile, only twice. In lines 7 and 8, the speaker describes how Otto's death shot Plath like a "bullet" down a set life course:

Your **Daddy** had been aiming you at God
When his death touched the trigger.

The second use of "Daddy" occurs near the end of the poem. In lines 33 and 34, the speaker identifies the real aim of Plath's bullet-like trajectory: "Your **Daddy**, / The god with the smoking gun." By limiting the repetition of "Daddy" to these two

instances, the speaker identifies Otto as a defining figure at the beginning and end of Plath's life. If Plath moved through life like a bullet, then Otto was both the hand that pulled the trigger and the target that Plath shot. In this way, repetition highlights how, in the poem's estimation, the death of Plath's "Daddy" was inherently linked to her own suicide in a nearly cyclical loop of family trauma and destruction.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** "god"
- **Line 3:** "gods"
- **Line 5:** "god"
- **Line 6:** "god," "god"
- **Line 7:** "Daddy," "God"
- **Line 33:** "Daddy"
- **Line 34:** "god"
- **Line 38:** "god"
- **Line 42:** "Godless"

APOSTROPHE

In "The Shot," Ted Hughes examines intimate details of his deceased wife Sylvia Plath's life, in particular how the death of her father led to her toxic relationships with other men and her eventual self-destruction. The poem recognizes this intimacy through its use of [apostrophe](#).

From the poem's first line to its last, the speaker uses the second person to address Plath directly. This technique calls attention to the speaker's personal relationship with Plath and thereby heightens the poem's emotional intensity. For example, in line 37, when the speaker claims, "**you** had gone clean through **me**," it's clear that the breakdown of his and Plath's relationship and her eventual suicide is deeply personal.

In a way, the sense of intimacy created by apostrophe also calls attention to the great *divide* between its speaker and his addressee. Hughes and Plath shared an infamously tumultuous relationship and were married but separated at the time of Plath's death. Talking to Plath directly in this poem highlights the fact that she is *not* actually present and is a reminder that she and the speaker were estranged towards the end of her life.

In the poem's final lines, the speaker laments that he could not halt Plath's fatal "Trajectory" but instead "managed" only to grasp at pieces of her: "A wisp of your hair, your ring, your watch, your nightgown." Here, the use of the second person highlights the speaker's emotional devastation. Even as he acknowledges how Plath has left him behind, he speaks directly to her. In this sense, apostrophe is a fitting device for "The Shot." It emulates the speaker's desire to make sense of that which cannot be altered, to speak to those who cannot respond.

Where Apostrophe appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-44

IDIOM

In "The Shot" Ted Hughes compares his former wife Sylvia Plath's short, destructive life to the trajectory of a bullet. The [idiom](#) "smoking gun" in line 34 of the poem works within the structure of this metaphor to emphasize the role Plath's father, Otto, played in her tragic fate (Plath died by suicide at the age of 30).

In line 8 of the poem, the speaker states that Otto's untimely death "touched the trigger" that shot Plath down her brutally powerful life course. In other words, according to the poem, the trauma of losing her father directly caused Plath's desperate desire to recreate or reunite with his powerful masculine presence, at the expense of others and herself.

Lines 32-33 confirm Otto's responsibility for the events of Plath's life:

Till your real target
Hid behind me. Your Daddy,
The god with the **smoking gun**.

Here, the poem reveals Otto as the "real target" of Plath's furious "flightpath," the ultimate object of her desire and devotion. Meanwhile, the idiom "smoking gun," which refers to a piece of inarguably incriminating evidence, meshes with the extended bullet metaphor introduced in line 8 to emphasize how, when he died, Plath's father determined the events of her life by creating an absence that she would ultimately bury herself to fill.

Where Idiom appears in the poem:

- **Lines 33-34:** "Your Daddy, / The god with the smoking gun"



VOCABULARY

Jocks (Line 3) - School or college athletes, particularly young men. The word is typically somewhat dismissive, and here it emphasizes just how normal the men Plath chose to worship were.

Infatuation (Line 4) - Obsessive but short-lived passion or admiration.

Deified (Line 4) - Turned into a god. The poem is saying that the intensity of Plath's passion made "ordinary" men seem all powerful and godlike.

Ricocheted (Lines 10-11) - Of a bullet, rebounded one or more

times off a surface. Here, the word conveys the speed and ferocity with which Plath moved through her life and career.

Kinetic energy (Lines 14-15) - A form of energy an object possesses because of its motion. The speaker is saying that the [metaphorical](#) Plath-bullet is not slowing down.

Elect (Lines 15-16) - People who are chosen. More specifically, the poem is nodding, with some [irony](#), to the idea of the "elect" in some Christian denominations, which refers to people picked by God for salvation: instead of being saved, Plath's "elect" are destroyed.

Speculative (Lines 17-18) - Based on a guess rather than knowledge; theoretical. Again, the poem is dismissing Plath's lovers as unreal and unsubstantial.

Provisional (Lines 17-18) - Serving for the time being; temporary. Plath's lovers were never serious, the poem argues, despite her intense infatuation.

Sodden (Line 20) - Saturated with water; soaked.

Diminuendo (Line 24) - A musical term for a gradual decrease in force or loudness. Here, the word refers to the way Plath's "panics" would dwindle down.

Ether (Line 28) - The clear upper regions of the sky. The poem is saying that Plath's "bullet" moves smoothly and swiftly, as though through unobstructed sky.

Rifling groove (Lines 30-31) - A groove inside the barrel of a rifle that exerts torque, causing a bullet to spin and thereby increasing its aerodynamic stability and accuracy. The poem argues that the [metaphorical](#) "groove" of Plath's cheek scar, a remnant from an earlier suicide attempt, keeps her steady on her destructive course.

Witchdoctor (Lines 39-40) - A traditional spiritual healer.

a gun goes off.

- In the second stanza, which is only six lines, the speaker shifts away from relaying the events of Plath's life and considers how they could have been altered under different circumstances. Thus, the stanza break also represents a shift as the poem turns from what *was* to what *might have been*.

Within both stanzas are several indented lines that create minor pauses in the poem's rapid forward momentum and signal slight changes in subject and tone. The indented lines in stanza 1 highlight the beginning and end of Plath's bullet-like course through life. Line 9—"In that flash"—signals a discussion of how Otto's death determined Plath's direction in life, while line 32—"Till your real target"—calls attention to Otto's influence on Plath's own death. Meanwhile, line 43 in stanza 2—"I managed"—represents the speaker's turn away from hypothetical considerations and toward acknowledging his own inability to prevent Plath's self-destruction.

METER

"The Shot" is written in [free verse](#), meaning it doesn't follow a consistent [meter](#). Meter often makes a poem sound formal and even musical, like a song, chant, or hymn. Thus, a *lack* of regular meter allows "The Shot" to take on an informal, conversational tone. Free verse mimics the unpredictable patterns of normal speech, which makes sense since "The Shot" is an intimate, second person address to the poet's deceased wife.

RHYME SCHEME

Because "The Shot" is a [free verse](#) poem, it also doesn't have a [rhyme scheme](#). This makes sense, considering that the poem is an intimate address and therefore mimics the unpredictable patterns of conversational speech. Furthermore, a strict rhyme scheme and regular [meter](#) might feel overly restrictive for a poem that describes a woman's powerful, destructive, unalterable journey. In a sense, the poem plows through the conventions of form, just as its subject plowed through obstacles on her bullet-like trajectory through life.



SPEAKER

"The Shot" is an autobiographical poem and its speaker is the poet himself, Ted Hughes. In "The Shot," Hughes tries to make sense of his former wife Sylvia Plath's relationship with her father, Otto, and how his death shaped the course of her life.

At the beginning of the poem, Hughes suggests that Otto's untimely death set Plath off on a bullet-like "Trajectory." Plath moved through life with passion, power, and determination, Hughes claims, the result of which was the destruction of herself and others. Hughes describes how Plath plowed through her lovers, none of whom could compare to the



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"The Shot" is a [free verse](#) poem and does not follow a traditional form. Instead, the poem has its own unique shape.

The poem's 44 lines can be divided into two [stanzas](#):

- The first 38 lines ("Your worship [...] heart of the god.") describes Sylvia Plath's bullet-like path through life. This stanza begins with the death of Plath's father, Otto, an event that pulls the [metaphorical](#) "trigger" that shoots Plath down her destructive "Trajectory." It ends when Plath reaches her "target"—reunion with her father via her own suicide. Thus, the first stanza encompasses the poem's metaphorical gunshot, from beginning to end. In this way, the stanza break marks the end of Plath's life while formally mimicking the silence after

powerful, masculine figure she lost when Otto died. He claims that Plath's struggles with mental health did not deter her from her course but rather helped her stay "true" to her ultimate goal—reunion with (and destruction of) Otto, which she ultimately achieved by committing suicide.

By directly addressing Plath, Hughes conveys the complexity of his emotions toward her. He exhibits a sense of awe when remembering the bullet-like power with which she moved through the world, describing her as "gold-jacketed, solid silver" and "Trajectory perfect / As through ether." However, Hughes also seems critical, or perhaps fearful, of the way Plath, in his words, destroyed and discarded her lovers as though they were "mind-stuff" or "mere auras."

Towards the end of the poem, Hughes recognizes that he, too, was a mere obstacle between Plath and her "real target," Otto. He claims Plath shot "clean through" him as though he were "mist." In this way, Hughes shows how bullet-like Plath made him feel insubstantial. Indeed, he concludes the poem by lamenting his inability to stop Plath's self-destruction. He was able to grasp only at pieces of her: a nightgown, a ring, a lock of hair. Thus, while Hughes addresses Plath directly, "The Shot" largely conveys his distance from her. Compared to Otto's all-consuming, nearly divine memory, Hughes feels powerless to alter Plath's tragic course.



SETTING

"The Shot" is based on the poet's memories of his deceased wife, Sylvia Plath, and his secondhand understanding of Plath's relationship with her father, Otto, whom he never met. The poem doesn't have a particular physical setting. Instead, "The Shot" describes the events of Plath's life, ranging from her father's death in 1940 to her own suicide in 1963. The poem was written many years later, and it, therefore, looks back on these events from a considerable distance. Speaking directly to Plath from the present, the speaker considers what might have been done differently to alter her tragic fate and laments his own inability to save her.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

British poet Ted Hughes (1930-1998) is widely considered to be one of the most influential writers of the 20th century. Deeply inspired by the rural landscape of his childhood, many of Hughes's poems focus on the ferocious beauty of the natural world. However, in his final collection, *Birthday Letters*, in which "The Shot" was published in 1998, Hughes turns toward more personal subject matter.

Birthday Letters explores Hughes's infamous relationship with

the American poet Sylvia Plath. The couple shared a tumultuous marriage and were separated at the time of Plath's death by suicide in 1963. Many blamed Hughes for Plath's death, suggesting that his infidelity drove her to suicide. As the executor of Plath's literary estate, Hughes also faced intense criticism for the editorial decisions he made concerning the posthumous publication of her journals, poems, and other works. Hughes declined to comment on these controversies for much of his life. *Birthday Letters*, published just a few months before his death, represents the most explicit, intimate perspective Hughes ever offered on a personal relationship that had taken on great literary, social, and cultural significance.

The collection, which Hughes wrote over a period of 25 years or so and revised extensively, caused a sensation upon publication. Hughes knew the poems were a departure from his other work because of their autobiographical content, [calling them](#) "so raw, so vulnerable, so unprocessed, so naive, so self-exposing and unguarded." The poems were clearly intended to bring Hughes a sense of closure, if not necessarily his readers: "I published it purely to get it off my chest and I'm indifferent to its fate," he once said.

"The Shot" also alludes and responds to Plath's famous poem, ["Daddy,"](#) in which she describes the overbearing presence of her father, Otto. "The Shot" picks up on this theme and, like "Daddy," notes how Plath used suicide as a method to get back to and back at her deceased father. Both "Daddy" and "The Shot" also suggest that Plath tried to replicate her and Otto's toxic dynamic within her romantic relationships. However, while in "Daddy" Plath imagines her triumph over the powerful, masculine father figure—"Daddy, you can lie back now. // There's a stake in your fat black heart"—in "The Shot," Hughes suggests that Plath's obsession with her father ultimately led to her own destruction: "you had gone clean through me— / To bury yourself at last in the heart of the god."

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Ted Hughes and American poet Sylvia Plath (1932-1963) met in February 1956 in Cambridge, England, where Plath was studying on a Fulbright scholarship. The couple were married by June of that year and quickly gained attention for their literary achievements. Plath and Hughes shared several years of happy, productive marriage, during which Plath had two children, Nicholas and Frieda. The marriage soon began to break down, however, and in 1962 Hughes had an affair. The couple's subsequent separation severely impacted Plath's emotional and psychological well-being and, after years of battling clinical depression, she died by suicide in 1963.

In addition to exploring Plath's romantic history, "The Shot" examines Plath's relationship with her father, Otto, a German immigrant who worked as an entomologist and professor of German and biology at Boston University. Otto Plath died in 1940 of advanced diabetes, which he had misdiagnosed as lung

cancer and for which he had refused to seek treatment. The event profoundly affected Plath, who was eight years old at the time. Indeed, while remarkably talented and ambitious, Plath dealt with severe emotional and psychological issues for much of her life. These struggles included a suicide attempt at age 20 that left a permanent scar on Plath's cheek, as referenced in line 28 of "The Shot."



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- ["Daddy" by Sylvia Plath](#) — Read "Daddy," the famous poem by Sylvia Plath to which Ted Hughes alludes in "The Shot." (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/48999/daddy-56d22aafa45b2>)
- [Plath's Account of Meeting Hughes](#) — Learn firsthand about the night Sylvia Plath met Ted Hughes in this intimate entry from Plath's journals, courtesy of the British Library. (<https://www.bl.uk/collection-items/sylvia-plaths-journal-26-february-1956>)
- [Sylvia Plath's Biography](#) — Learn more about Sylvia Plath's life and work from this short biography, courtesy of the Poetry Foundation. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/sylvia-plath>)
- [Ted Hughes's Biography](#) — Learn more about Hughes's life and work in this short biography, courtesy of the Poetry Foundation. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/ted-hughes>)
- [An Introduction to Birthday Letters](#) — Read more about the creation and content of Birthday Letters, the 1998 poetry collection in which "A Shot" was published, via The

British Library. (<https://www.bl.uk/20th-century-literature/articles/an-introduction-to-birthday-letters>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER TED HUGHES POEMS

- [A Memory](#)
- [Anniversary](#)
- [A Picture of Otto](#)
- [Bayonet Charge](#)
- [Cat and Mouse](#)
- [Football at Slack](#)
- [Hawk Roosting](#)
- [Relic](#)
- [Roe-Deer](#)
- [Snowdrop](#)
- [Telegraph Wires](#)
- [The Harvest Moon](#)
- [The Horses](#)
- [The Jaguar](#)
- [The Other](#)
- [The Thought Fox](#)
- [Wind](#)



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